

The word of the LORD also came unto me, saying, Son of **12** man, thou dwellest in the midst of a rebellious house, which ² have eyes to see, and see not ; they have ears to hear, and hear not : for they *are* a rebellious house. Therefore thou ³

Has it not been a persistent course of ingratitude and unfaithfulness? Can the issue of it be anything but destruction?

(6) ch. xvii. And the perfidy of Zedekiah against the king of Babylon, must it not be chastised?

(7) ch. xviii. The principles of the divine government.

(8) ch. xix. Dirge over Judah and her royal house.

CH. XII. SYMBOL OF THE FLIGHT AND CAPTURE OF THE KING.

The passage is without date, but the signs were subsequent to those already described. The first part, vv. 1—20, is rather of the nature of a preface, repeating the certainty of the downfall of the city and nation, while all that follows up to ch. xix. supports this certainty by shewing the moral necessity of Israel's destruction.

(1) vv. 1—2. An introduction characterizing the house of Israel as blind and unable to discern the signs of the times, and therefore in need of new proofs to convince them.

(2) vv. 3—7. A symbolical action, prefiguring the fate of the king and people on the capture of the city.

(3) vv. 8—16. Exposition of the symbol: the failure of Zedekiah's attempt at resistance, his flight and capture, exile and death in Babylon, with the dispersion of the people into all lands.

(4) vv. 17—20. A new symbol of the life of anguish and terror which the people shall lead under the foreign invaders.

(5) vv. 21—25. Warning against a proverb current in Israel to the effect that "visions," that is, prophecies of evil, did not come true.

(6) vv. 26—28. Warning against a less blameable form of unbelief, the idea that prophecies, such as those now given, referred to a distant time, and that it would be long ere they were fulfilled.

2. The people of Israel among whom the prophet dwells is a rebellious house (ch. ii. 3, 6, 7, 8, iii. 26, 27). His former signs meet with no belief from them. They have eyes but see not : they behold events and history with their bodily eyes, but fail to discern the moral meaning in them. Events are just events to them, the nature of the God who animates the events remains undiscovered by them (Is. vi. 9, xlii. 20 ; Jer. v. 21 ; Mark viii. 18). And the signs and words of the prophet make no impression on them ; they say, "Doth he not speak parables?" (ch. xx. 49). Therefore new signs must be given them (v. 4).

3—7. SYMBOLICAL ACTION, PREFIGURING THE ESCAPE AND CAPTURE OF THE FUGITIVES.

The details of the symbol seem to be as follows : First, the prophet prepares "stuff for removing"—such articles as one meaning to escape would carry with him. These things being prepared, he brings them

son of man, prepare thee stuff for removing, and remove by day in their sight; and thou shalt remove from thy place to another place in their sight: it may be they will consider, though they *be* a rebellious house. Then shalt thou bring forth thy stuff by day in their sight, as stuff for removing: and thou shalt go forth at even in their sight, as they that go forth into captivity. Dig thou through the wall in their sight, and carry out thereby. In their sight shalt thou bear

out. It is not said where he deposits them; it would be in some place convenient to make his escape from, in the vicinity of the wall of the city. These things he does before the eyes of the people during daylight. His action represents the conduct of persons in a besieged city, whose movements are free within the city; hence this part of the action is done openly (vv. 3, 4). Secondly, these preparations having been made by day, the prophet himself goes out in the even, in the darkness, and digs through the wall, making his escape at the opening, and carrying on his shoulder the articles which he had prepared to take with him in his flight. Besides doing this in the darkness he covers his face. In doing all this he is a "sign" to the house of Israel: in this way shall the king and those with him seek to escape into exile from the enemy when the city is about to fall into their hands (vv. 4—7).

3. *stuff for removing*] Lit. articles of exile, i.e. such articles as one carries with him when going as a fugitive into exile.

and remove by day] Lit. remove as into exile. The word is wanting in LXX., which reads: prepare for thyself articles of exile by day in their sight. This is more natural.

remove from thy place] The words seem to describe generally the whole symbolical action which the prophet is to perform.

though they be a rebellious] **for they are.**

4. *Then shalt thou bring*] **And thou shalt.** The prophet is to bring forth the articles which he had prepared, depositing them in some convenient place in readiness to carry with him when he escapes.

and thou shalt go forth] Possibly: and thou shalt go forth thyself, as R.V. The second half of v. 4 is to be connected with v. 5, describing the prophet's action so far as it symbolizes what refers to the persons of the fugitives.

5. *Dig through the wall*] Naturally the "wall" is not the wall of his house, but the city wall. He brought out his articles of flight by day, making them ready for the night-time when he was to escape through the wall. It is absurd to suppose, as is usually done, that he carried his things back into the house, and digged through the wall of his house in the evening. This would mar the action and be ridiculous. The "wall" is the city wall. The question whether Tel Abib was a walled place is of no importance, because the actions were probably not actually performed.

6. The verse refers to the prophet's going out through the city wall,

it upon *thy* shoulders, and carry *it* forth in the twilight: thou shalt cover thy face, that thou see not the ground: for I have set thee *for* a sign unto the house of Israel. And I ⁷ did so as I was commanded: I brought forth my stuff by day, as stuff for captivity, and in the even I digged through the wall with mine hand; I brought *it* forth in the twilight, and I bare *it* upon *my* shoulder in their sight.

And in the morning came the word of the LORD unto me, ⁸ saying, Son of man, hath not the house of Israel, the rebellious house, said unto thee, What doest thou? Say thou ¹⁰ unto them, Thus saith the Lord GOD; This burden *concerneth* the prince in Jerusalem, and all the house of Israel

bearing on his shoulder the bundle of articles he carried with him in his flight.

in the twilight] in the **darkness**. So *v.* 7. The word again only Gen. xv. 17.

cover thy face] This might be to disguise himself, but the next words "thou shalt not see the land" (ground) seem to require a different sense. Cf. *vv.* 12, 13.

a sign unto...Israel] A typical sign, as explained *v.* 11, "As I have done so shall it be done unto them." Comp. ch. xxiv. 24, 27; Is. viii. 18; xx. 3; Zech. iii. 8.

⁷. *with mine hand*] lit. *with hand*, i.e. by force, Is. xxviii. 2. LXX. omits.

in the twilight] the **darkness**, as *v.* 6, so *v.* 12.

vv. 8—16. Exposition of the symbol.

The action of the prophet is a representation of what shall happen in the last days of the siege. The king and those about him shall prepare for flight; they shall go out secretly through the walls, but shall be captured and brought to Babylon.

⁸, ⁹. *in the morning*] This circumstance might seem to imply that the prophet really performed the actions described. But though in this case performance of the action was not an impossibility it was probably only narrated (see on ch. iv.). The natural sequel of the action (supposing it done), the curiosity of the people, is described, just as the action itself was, as if it had literally been shewn.

¹⁰, ¹¹. The general meaning of these verses is clear enough—the prophet's action is a representation of what shall happen in Jerusalem in the case of prince and people, but *v.* 10 is very obscure, and probably not in its original form.

This burden concerneth the prince] lit. *the prince* (is) *this burden* in Jerusalem. The term "burden" has also the sense of "oracle," but Ez. does not use it in this sense and there is no reason to find any play upon the word as Jer. xxiii. 33. The allusion can only be to the last words of *v.* 7—I bare *it* upon my shoulder; and the meaning would be: this bearing or loading has reference to the prince (*v.* 12). With this

- 11 that *are* among them. Say, I *am* your sign : like as I have done, so shall it be done unto them : they shall remove *and*
 12 go into captivity. And the prince that *is* among them shall bear upon *his* shoulder in the twilight, and shall go forth : they shall dig through the wall to carry out thereby : he shall cover his face, that he see not the ground with *his* eyes.
 13 My net also will I spread upon him, and he shall be taken in my snare : and I will bring him to Babylon *to* the land of the Chaldeans ; yet shall he not see it, though he shall die

sense the following words must run : and all the house of Israel which are in the midst of it (Jerusalem—with a change of one letter). The objection to this that if the relative were subject the pronoun would not be expressed after it (Hitz., Keil) is worthless. But there are other objections more valid : “all the house of Israel” could hardly be used of the inhabitants of Jerusalem, the phrase usually refers to the larger Israel, existing in all places. R.V. “this burden *concerneth* the prince...and all the house of Israel among whom they are;” but *concerneth* is said of the “prince” and of “all the house of Israel” in different senses. Notwithstanding the objections to it the easiest course is to read: *in the midst of it* (Jerusalem) as above. Corn. omits the verse as a gloss.

11. *I am your sign*] i.e. a sign to you—the exiles, to whom he is speaking; while done “to them” refers to the inhabitants of Jerusalem. Cf. v. 6.

12. *shoulder in the twilight, and shall*] The balance of clauses requires: shall bear upon his shoulder; in the darkness shall he go forth (or, carry forth—a slight change of reading, which obviates the unnatural *and*).

that he see not the ground] Rather as R.V., because he shall not see the land.

with his eyes] Lit. *by eyesight himself*. The language is unnatural. LXX. “that he may not be seen by eye, and he himself shall not see the land.” Whether original or not this rendering combines the two ideas expressed by “covering the face,” viz. that of disguise (Job xxiv. 15), and that of inability to see (Job ix. 24). The prophet clearly foresaw the fate of the city and the captivity of the king, and he may have threatened the king with a chastisement for his rebellion which, though barbarous, was not unusual in that age. If he did so it is still probable that afterwards when composing his Book he made the references to the putting out of the king’s eyes more distinct (v. 13).

13. The king’s flight shall be unavailing; he shall be captured and brought blinded to Babylon, where he shall die. As the Lord fought against Jerusalem in the siege, so it is he that ensures the capture of the king. It is in his net that he is ensnared and taken; Hos. vii. 12, “when they go, I will spread my net upon them; I will bring them down as the fowls of heaven.” Cf. Ez. xvii. 20; xxxii. 3.

yet shall he not see it] The eyes of Zedekiah were put out by Nebuchadnezzar at Riblah. 2 Kings xxv. 5 *seq.*; Jer. lii. 8, 11.